

DELEGATE's Corner

Celebrating 80 Years of Recovery, Unity and Service -The Foundation for Our Future

My name is Cesar and I am an alcoholic. I have the honor to serve Mid-Southern California Area 09 as Panel 64 Delegate. My Conference Committee is Public Information.

I started to drink when I was 14 years old. As the oldest of 5 brothers, my parents had many of their dreams in me; but my drinking habits coupled with a bad attitude and conduct, I didn't make any good decisions. My habits were not so good and neither were my friendships. Very soon I turned into an alcoholic with many problems. At 20 years of age I moved to California looking for ways to improve my life, but my problems came with me and things only got worse. It was then that an A.A. member with much patience and tolerance took me to my first A.A. meeting. 19 years ago I first entered through the doors of A.A. and have not had a drink since then.

During my early days in A.A., I didn't care much about the Traditions or the Concepts. My focus was on the Steps. After practicing these, gratitude began to flourish within me; gratitude toward our community as a whole. It was then during a business meeting at my home group, I raised my hand to serve in General Service. My quality of life changed and my sobriety was enriched with the spiritual experiences that I have lived through by walking this path. At times, I feel afraid and nervous to take on some extra work that I may not be able to perform; but as usual, I feel strongly inspired by this love I feel for A.A.

I have been in General Service now for 16 years. When making myself available for Delegate, I have had my name, on two different occasions picked from the hat. The Higher Power of my understanding said "no" both times. On the third time, my name was again picked from the hat. This time, my Higher Power said "yes". And from then on, all the interesting things started to unfold. Just as I had been warned, my life was going to change, but I was never told to what magnitude.

I continue to attend my home group meetings, being a sponsor to newcomers, taking care of my responsibilities and all at the same time, enjoying my service as Delegate -- best of all, living this spiritual experience to the max.

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AREA 09 UPCOMING EVENTS



May 17 -Sunday ASSEMBLY

Hosted by District 25

June 14 -Sunday ASC

Hosted by District 2

July 12 -Sunday FORO

Hosted by District 23 & 8

August 9 -Sunday ASC

Hosted by District 3

September 13 -Sunday ASSEMBLY

Hosted by District 11

October 11 -Sunday ELECTIONS

Hosted by District 4

November 8 -Sunday ASC

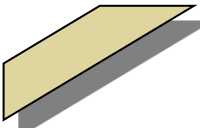
Hosted by District 17

November 14 -Saturday SERVATHON

Hosted by District 1

December 13 -Sunday ASC

Hosted by District 30



Soon we will celebrate 80 years of our fellowship. It makes me think about our A.A. pioneers including Dr. Bob and Bill W., who left this program for future generations. A.A. is now in other countries and other cultures. Today, we can appreciate that there is A.A. activity all over the world. It is a privilege to go and see the diversity in our Area with the groups we have -- meetings in Farsi, Spanish, Japanese and meetings with American Sign Language, (ASL) interpreters. We have committees putting on events, workshops, and round tables to motivate members so our groups can carry the message to the alcoholic who still suffers. Many times I see committees with little participation, other events with a lot, where I travel within our Area visiting groups, districts, committees, central offices and some other local events to which I have been invited.

All of these committees, meetings, and events I mentioned talk about our 80 years Celebration. I can see and feel that our members are taking the responsibility that our pioneers left in our care. Whenever I have an opportunity, I thank our English speaking members for allowing us, the Spanish speaking community, into the A.A. structure so we can participate and share our experience. I want to take this opportunity to say to all of you: "Thank you, Thank you, Thank you for your support."

I am grateful to our early pioneers for seeing the wisdom in our spirit of inclusiveness, our heritage of inclusion and diversity within A.A. As it appears in Bill's essay on Tradition Three, our early years were gripped with fear. A.A. was fragile and recovery so precious. Recovery should be open to all who suffer from alcoholism. We, in Alcoholics Anonymous have a solution. We can never deny that solution to our fellow sufferers regardless of race, religion, atheist, agnostic, culture, gender, sexual orientation, background, or personality.

Our heritage of diversity continues to grow. In 1958 the Conference recognized the original use of the word "honest" before the phrase "desire to stop drinking" and its deletion from the Traditions as part of the evolution of the A.A. movement. In 1968 the Conference voted for the first World Service meeting to be held in New York. As we can see from our current Conference proposals, we continue to this day evolving towards inclusion. In 1985, Area 09 approved its first Spanish speaking District. Today we have six of them. As you know, I come from a culture where we practice and celebrate to a different level with music, dance, and noise. I see that this equates to our gratitude for A.A. But we must keep in mind that we have a responsibility to move forward, to continue to carry this message of life to other ethnic groups within our Area. There is much work to be done and that is what I promote every time I have an opportunity.

I have seen our literature with booklets and books that have been added through the years, and committees, all due to a particular need. I like this and feel proud to belong to this great movement that cares for all and not only for a particular group of people. I hope this will always be the character of A.A., with a vision to the future, to reach out to all

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A.A. HISTORY MAY

May 1

1939 - Lois and Bill W. left their home at 182 Clinton St., Brooklyn.

1940 - Rollie H., Cleveland Indians, anonymity break occurred.

1941 - First Wisconsin AA meeting was held in hotel in Milwaukee.

May 2

1941 - Jacksonville, FL newspaper reported the start of an AA group in Jacksonville.

1943 - *New Orleans Times* reported founding of the first Louisiana AA group with a dozen members.

May 3

1941 - First AA group formed in New Orleans, Louisiana.

1941 - *Democrat Chronicle* in Rochester, NY, reported first annual AA dinner at Seneca hotel with 60 attending.

May 4

1940 - *Sunday Star* reported founding of first AA group in Washington, DC.

May 6

1939 - Clarence S. of Cleveland told Dr. Bob, his sponsor, he would not be back to Oxford Group meetings in Akron and would start an "AA" meeting in Cleveland.

May 7

1956 - The first English AA Convention was held in Cheltenham, England.

May 8

1943 - Akron AA Group celebrates 8th anniversary with 500 present and sober.

1971 - Bill W. was buried in private ceremony, in East Dorset, Vermont. Dr. Jack Norris gave the eulogy.

May 10

1939 - Clarence S. announced to the Akron Oxford Group members that the Cleveland members were starting a meeting in Cleveland and calling it Alcoholics Anonymous.

1946 - Searcy W. had his last drink. (Died September 30, 2003 with 57 years continuous sobriety.)

types of alcoholics that still suffer, no matter whom they are or where they come from -- because they will be the future members and trusted servants of Alcoholic Anonymous. That is why it is my duty to reflect on and to honor our A.A. principles by my own example.

We should celebrate, and celebrate proudly. We should let our gratitude shine. A.A. grew from humble beginnings and has come so far. Lives have been saved and changed forever. Not just we drunks, but all of the people we love and who love us. We were supposed to be hopeless and destined to ruin. But our founders stumbled upon grace, that of one drunk helping another. And from that came our Steps, Traditions, and Concepts. We had a lot of help, but we listened and accepted. It is a miracle that this little flame has grown such as it has. But, while we celebrate, we must not lose sight that we still have work to do, to expand upon our spirit of diversity and to make all who suffer from alcoholism feel welcome.

In this journey I have laughed; I have gotten mad; I have cried; I have been sad a few times; but above all, I have lived life to the fullest. With this ideal, this topic invites me to celebrate, but with responsibility. I know that we have done wonderful things together, but there is still more to do, so I must remember there is a legacy to follow.

My heart is full of blessings and of gratitude for this opportunity, thinking back from when I took my first drink, to my last. This journey has been the most remarkable ever in my life. I know it will be extremely hard to pay my debt to A.A., because the more I try to pay with service, the more blessings arrive and the debt continues to grow.

I would like to conclude saying I will be greatly thankful for the rest of my life. I love Alcoholic Anonymous and thank you for my life and for my sobriety.

Service is a Legacy of Love,
Cesar F., Panel 64 Delegate
Mid-Southern California Area 09



Each Alcoholics Anonymous group ought to be a spiritual entity having but one primary purpose—that of carrying its message to the alcoholic who still suffers.

Because it has now become plain enough that only a recovered alcoholic can do much for a sick alcoholic, a tremendous responsibility has descended upon us all, an obligation so great that it amounts to a sacred trust. For to our kind, those who suffer alcoholism, recovery is a matter of life or death. So the society of Alcoholics Anonymous cannot, it dare not ever be diverted from its primary purpose.

Bill W.
A.A. Grapevine, April, 1948

A.A. HISTORY MAY ... continued

May 11

1935 - Bill W. called Walter Tunks from the Mayflower Hotel, and was referred to Henrietta Seiberling who set up a meeting with Dr. Bob

May 12

1935 - Mother's Day, Bill and Dr. Bob met for the first time, at the home of Henrietta Seiberling.

May 15

1961 - Bill W.'s mother, Dr. Emily Strobell, died.

May 16

1941 - Ruth Hock learned that the man credited with coming up with the name "Alcoholics Anonymous" has a "wet" brain.

May 17

1942 - *Dayton Journal Herald* published pictures of AA members wearing masks to protect their anonymity.

May 18

1939 - The first group to call itself A. A. is meets in Cleveland, OH.

1950 - Dr. Bob told Bill W. "I reckon we ought to be buried like other folks." He wanted no memorial.

May 19

2000 - Dr. Paul O. died at the age of 83. He was author of "Acceptance Was the Answer" in the 4th edition of the Big Book. This story was titled "Doctor, Alcoholic, Addict" in the 3rd edition.

May 29

1980 - "Dr. Bob and the Good Old Timers" was published.

May 31

1938 - Bill W. and other A.A.s began writing the Big Book.

May without specific dates:

1938 - Bill W. and other AA's began writing the Big Book.

1939 - Clarence Snyder told Dr. Bob, his sponsor, he would not be back to the Oxford Group meetings in Akron and would start an "A.A." meeting in Cleveland.

Admitted to God, to ourselves, and to another human being the exact nature of our wrongs.



..... Trying to avoid this humbling experience, they have turned to easier methods. Almost invariably they got drunk. Having persevered with the rest of the program, they wondered why they fell. We think the reason is that they never completed their housecleaning. They took inventory all right, but hung on to some of the worst items in stock. They only thought they had lost their egoism and fear; they only thought they had humbled themselves.

But they had not learned enough of humility, fearlessness and honesty, in the sense we find it necessary, until they told someone else all their life story.

...We must be entirely honest with somebody if we expect to live long or happily in this world. ...The rule is we must be hard on our self, but always considerate of others.

- ALCOHOLICS ANONYMOUS, PAGES 72-74



"If you can see me,
I'm the least of your problems."



May without specific dates... cont'd

1942 - Richmond W., author of "24 Hours a Day," had his last drink.

1946 - Long form of 12 Traditions was published in AA Grapevine for the first time.

1946 - The A.A. *Grapevine* announced, "A.A. has 6,000 members in 180 groups."

1948 - The A.A. *Grapevine* reported \$2.00 was sent to the General Service headquarters of A.A. in New York, asking for "a bottle of Alcoholics Anonymous".

1950 - Nell Wing became Bill W.'s secretary.

1951 - Al-Anon was founded by Lois W. and Anne B.

1962 - The A. A. *Grapevine* published the first "Victor E." cartoon.



Throughout our world services structure, a traditional "Right of Appeal" ought to prevail, thus assuring us that minority opinion will be heard and that petitions for the redress of personal grievances will be carefully considered.

- Do we encourage the minority opinion, the "Right of Appeal," to be heard at our home group, district committee meetings, area assemblies and the Conference?
- What does our group accept as "substantial unanimity"?
- Has our group experienced the "tyranny of the majority" or the "tyranny of the minority"?
- Does our group understand the importance of all points of view being heard before a vote is taken?